

The Role Of
GUSTAV STRESSEMAN
In Post War Germany



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“Select a prominent figure and research that person’s background, role and contribution in relation to the period of study. Explain why they did it and the significance and impacts they had on society and events to follow.”

Prior to World War I, Germany was ruled by an emperor, known internationally as Kaiser Wilhelm II. The Kaiser was known for his fiery emotion and charismatic leadership skills, and believed that a war should commence as “Germany must have her place in the sun,” meaning, become equal to the world powers of the 18th century (more specifically, the Allies). After Germany was defeated, the Kaiser was forced to abdicate, and a new government was formed, known today as the Weimar Republic. The new republic was frowned upon and outwardly hated by Germans at the time, as it was seen as weak, unstable and unfit to function. However, Germany’s Golden Age (also known as the Stresemann Years) was a time period of drastic economic and cultural development as a result of temporary political stability and efficiency. This era of change and growth is almost solely due to the leadership of Chancellor Gustav Ernst Stresemann (1878-1929). Stresemann’s background in education and business and his motivation to achieve his apparitions worked to gain him entry into the Reichstag. These, along with his roles as Chancellor of Germany in 1923 and Foreign Minister until 1929, and his influence on the dreadful economic, political and social situations within Germany had a great effect on solidifying his significance as a historical figure during the years post WWI. Stresemann’s time at University and experience in the field of political economics aided his nationalist childhood ambitions greatly, and moved him to achieve his life aspirations and goals. His time as Chancellor involved various key decisions, such as ending passive resistance during the Ruhr crisis and introducing the Rentenmark, and his time as Foreign minister saw Germany gain foreign loans to grow their economy and a permanent place within the League Of Nations. His economic, political and social influence on the Allies and Germany throughout the decade solidified his historical importance as a significant figure during the 1920s, as the things he did for Germany greatly aided it’s recovery after WWI and the effect of the Treaty Of Versailles.

Stresemann’s background in education and business hugely assisted his significance as a historical figure in relation to the recovery of Germany post WWI. This was largely due to his schooling, interests and ambitions as a student, and the connections he made upon leaving university. Stresemann was born to parents Ernst and Matilda on the 10th of May 1878, in Berlin, as their seventh child. Due to their upper-middle class status, Gustav’s family could

afford to provide all of their children with high-quality education. During his high school years, many noticed Stresemann's passion for composing and writing and, upon attending the University of Berlin (1897), his true talent was revealed. He took up the role of newspaper editor for his fraternity, and his writing was described as logical, politically critical, liberal and nationalistic. Upon graduating with a doctorate in political economy, Stresemann developed and aided various businesses, made social and political connections and worked his way up to popularity among the powerful individuals of Germany, until eventually he was elected into the Reichstag in 1907 as a member of the National Liberal Party. At only 28 years old, Stresemann had become the youngest ever member of the Reichstag. This was his first step to forming his reputation as a renowned political mind of the 18th century. Stresemann's background in education and business contributed largely to his national significance within Germany during the years post WWI as a significant historical figure.

Stresemann's motivation to achieve his ambitions and aspirations was also a large contribution to his overall significance to Germany during the 1920s. Gustav had always had a passion for economics, politics and literature. His talent for rationality and thoughtful pragmatism had opened many different career options for young Gustav, and he could have easily become a successful teacher or lecturer. However, this did not meet his ambitions. Since being introduced to politics and debate during his high school years, Stresemann had harboured a dream of aiding his country in becoming a great and stable nation, and it was this dream that motivated him throughout his entire career as both a politician and an international correspondent. After the First World War, Stresemann's goals changed slightly, and he became a little more right wing in his views. It became his main focus to improve the German economy and capital, and to improve relations with the Allies and the rest of the world, as to increase the country's global economic power. These goals lead Stresemann on to do great things for Germany and better it's situation, and contributed to his overall significance as a historical figure within Germany during the time period.

It was Stresemann's roles as chancellor of Germany in 1923 that solidified his national significance to Germany during the years post WWI. Although he only served as chancellor for 102 days, Stresemann completely changed the approach the German government was taking towards economic crisis, specifically, the occupation of the Ruhr and hyperinflation. He was appointed on the 13th of August, during the occupation of the Ruhr. Throughout July, the Weimar Republic was struggling to pay reparations, so they lowered payments without the permission of the Allies. The French took this decision the worst, and in response forcibly occupied the Ruhr. The local coal miners began a passive resistance movement against French troops, and tensions between the two nations began to rise. One of Stresemann's first moves after his election was to end passive resistance in the Ruhr (via article 48), as to avoid further conflict with the Allies, and to persuade the French to leave peacefully upon an agreement to resume reparations payments. His key decision to attempt fulfilment of the treaty and reparations did not sit well with many in Germany at the time, but it prevented any violent escalation between nations, and later caused the Allies to review the extent of the set reparations. Next, Stresemann set about dealing with the instability of the German economy, or more specifically, the currency. The Mark was unstable from the economic toll of war and reparations. At first, the government tried to resolve the issue by simply printing more money. By November, Germany had entered a hyperinflation crisis, causing a ridiculous rise in the price of goods, and a mass loss of saving as the currency lost its worth. Stresemann's solution to this issue was to completely abolish the Mark and introduce a new currency – the Rentenmark. This decision marked the beginning of a stabilisation period within the German economy not seen since before the war, and paved the way for Germany's prosperity into the Golden Age. The role Stresemann had as Chancellor of Germany solidified his significance as a historical figure within Germany during the time period.

Stresemann's role as Foreign Minister until 1929 was also a factor that solidified his significance to Germany during the 1920s. Even after his resignation as chancellor on the 23rd of November, 1923, Stresemann was still a major leading figure upon Germany's political scene. immediately after resignation, he took up the position of Foreign Minister, and operated as chief of international relations until his death in 1929. During this time, he made

various key decisions and arguments that aided in the future prosperity of Germany. As the international spokesperson for his nation, Stresemann advocated for a review of the Allies' reparations plan. His negotiation skills led to a review in 1924, and as a result the Dawes Plan was developed. This plan involved the loaning of money from the United States of America to support the recovering German economy, and was enacted on the 19th of August that same year. There was another review of the reparations scheme in 1928, again pushed by Stresemann, and this again resulted in a similar plan – the Young Plan. The Young Plan mainly involved the restoration of Germany's financial and economic agency and independence in relation to maintaining steady reparations payments and suchlike. These two plans that Stresemann advocated for greatly minimised the economic toll on Germany during these tough years. Stresemann was also responsible for Germany's place in the League of Nations. On the 9th of September, 1926, Germany was accepted into the League as a full member, and given a seat among the other powerful nations. This re-involved Germany in international affairs, and regained them global status as a world power. Stresemann continued on with improving Germany's situation until his death. It was on the 3rd of October in 1929 that he suffered a stroke, and died at the age of 51. Stresemann's key role as Foreign Minister during the years after his resignation as chancellor greatly contributed to his global significance as an important historical figure during the 1920s.

Stresemann's influences on the economic, political and social aspects of German society during the 1920s contributed greatly to his significance as an important historical figure. His actions during his time as Chancellor and Foreign Minister gave him a good vantage point to enact changes within his struggling nation and positively influence all aspects of German life, the very changes that shaped the Golden Age. He improved the economy by bringing stability and growth to the German market unseen after the First World War, and he reopened trade relationships with the other nations. This flourish in economic development meant that Germans were free from crippling financial burden, and it drastically improved German industry and businesses. However, employment rates were extremely low. Stresemann also improved Germany's political situation, as Chancellor and Foreign Minister, as he brought a temporary era of stability. The contentedness of the population lessened extremist party

influences (such as the communist and Nazi parties) and caused hatred or distrust for the Weimar Republic to fade. The apparent solution to the issues of financial crisis also helped as it took pressure off of the government, and the opening of foreign trade and relations made Germany more involved in the greater international scheme. Stresemann also managed to improve the social aspects of Germany, as the opening of Germany to the rest of the world created a flourish of new German culture. The Golden Age is known well for the abundance of changes in literature, art, fashion and social norms, and the similarity of this situation to that of America during the roaring 20s. The Golden Age was a time period of great economic, political and social change and development for Germany, and it was Gustav Stresemann who changed these aspects of life through his actions for the better. His influence on Germany during the 1920s solidified his major significance as a historical figure.

Gustav Stresemann is a majorly significant historical figure as he played a large role in aiding Germany during the 1920s. This is due to how he changed and influenced Germany during the years post WWI and saved Germany from economic, financial and (arguably) political collapse during the 1920s. Stresemann is remembered today for his successful diplomacy as chancellor when he deescalated the occupation of the Ruhr, and his solution to hyperinflation in the form of the Rentenmark. These actions saved Germany from more conflict with the Allies and complete financial devastation during the decade. Stresemann is also remembered for his time as foreign minister, and his advocacy for the Dawes and Young Plans. These plans effectively supplied the financial support that Germany needed to grow and develop their nation, and gave fuel to the Golden Age, a time when Germany's economy, culture and industry flourished. Stresemann is also remembered for how he gained Germany a seat in the League of Nations. This gave Germany a means of re-involving itself with international affairs, and reopened more international relations for trade and communications. Gustav Stresemann is a hugely significant historical figure, as he did a lot of good things for Germany during the years post WWI.

Gustav Stresemann's background in education and business, accompanied by his motivation to achieve his goals, lead to his key roles as both chancellor of Germany in 1923 and foreign

minister until his unfortunate death in 1929. The influence that his roles had on the situation of Germany during the 1920s worked to solidify his status as a significant historical figure. It was his time during university that young Gustav developed his logical approach to diplomacy, and his time forming businesses and connections that gained him entry to the Reichstag. His nationalist and capitalist goals to improve German economy were major motivations for Stresemann's aims to succeed, and his methods of dealing with crisis in both the Ruhr and within the German financial sector avoided any further damages to international relations and the country itself. It was also Stresemann's actions during his time as foreign minister that he made curtail decisions for Germany, such as passing the Dawes and Young Plans, and gaining Germany a seat in the League Of Nations. The influence his actions had on the economic, political and social aspects of Germany during the 1920s were a definite conviction of his importance as a leader, and his huge significance as a historical figure. Stresemann was an individual that set Germany on a path to international recognition and importance. It could be said that Stresemann began Germany's journey towards finally gaining "her place in the sun" among the Allies, what Kaiser Wilhelm had fought so hard for during the First World War, but had never achieved.

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In class notes, information and worksheets, provided by Mr Adam Harris, 2018.

People:

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